



**ADVANI WITH
BHAGWAT (RIGHT)**

Hindutva and development. Even Madhya Pradesh was able to retain a majority of the seats because of Shivraj Singh Chouhan—a young chief minister with an RSS background. Former and current chief ministers along with deputy chief ministers like Raman Singh, Narendra Modi, Prem Kumar Dhumal, B.S. Yeddyurappa, Manohar Parrikar and Gopinath Munde are capable of turning around the fortunes of the party if they are given a meaningful role in party affairs and are not ordered around by those who can't win their own elections. The combined credibility and influence of these comparatively young, successful chief ministers can be a formidable threat to the Congress which has none to match them. Since the future of the RSS depends on the new allies it can gather in the future, only a credible leader can carry conviction. The party under Advani could get an ally in the south and lose one in Orissa because lightweight emissaries with no political experience were chosen as inter-

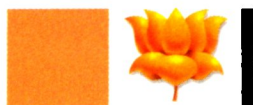
locutors instead of former chief ministers. In the south, the party couldn't retain a single seat in the three states of Kerala, Tamil Nadu and Andhra Pradesh and it has failed to grow in Uttar Pradesh which once sent 59 BJP members to the Lok Sabha.

There are also those in the party who feel that Varun Gandhi can revive the party in Uttar Pradesh as its traditional voters feel that the BJP let them down on the Hindutva plank. Varun won his own seat with one of the highest margins in Uttar Pradesh, more than the victory margin of the party's prime ministerial candidate. Those who are rooting for the silent majority feel that the days of the personality cult are over. With both Advani and Vajpayee about to retire from active politics, the BJP has to establish a collective leadership to steer the party in the future. And in the new dispensation, the Byte and Cosmetic Generation will have to pave

the way for those who are performers and can carry the masses and not just the classes. The message from verdict 2009 is quite clear. The voters want a party with a genuine difference and not differences based on personal animosities. They want a leader with an ideology and not a leader with mere aspirations. The decline of the BJP is also a cause for concern. In the absence of a cohesive opposition, the country may face an autocratic ruling party, blinded by arrogance and lack of political restraints.

The BJP flirted with the idea of individual superiority over ideology under Vajpayee and won the mandate. But the same voters rejected Advani who had no definable ideology. Now, the party has to find itself a face which looks more like Bharat and less like India. To achieve that, it has to first replace the drawing room strategists who walk the ramp of political fashion shows with those who can survive in the heat and dust of the India the party forgot.

with Bhavna Vij-Aurora



RSS chief Mohan

Bhagwat has so far chosen to be non-interventionist but is expected to play a more proactive role.